
**Unit 1, Option D,
Topic D4: Stalin's
Russia, 1924-53**

The focus of this topic is on the most dramatic and traumatic years of Soviet history under the leadership of Joseph Stalin. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of power and the influence of ideology. The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on the reason for changes in agricultural policies would draw on both the first and second bullet points.

The first bullet point relates to the struggle for power between Trotsky, Zinoviev, Kamenev, Bukharin and Stalin in the five years following Lenin's death. Students should understand the policy issues at stake, relating to the continuation of NEP and the question of 'socialism in one country' as opposed to 'world revolution' and the influence of both personalities and the political institutions of the new Soviet Union in determining the outcome by 1929.

The second bullet point relates to the important changes in social and economic policies between 1928 and 1941. Students should understand the reasons for the decision to promote collectivisation and its effects not just on rural areas but its connection to industrialisation and urbanisation. The changing nature and priorities of the three five-year plans should be addressed and the successes and failures of these plans. Changing social policies refers to the changing government policies on education, the family and divorce.

The third bullet point relates to the features of the regime that have been described as totalitarian. Students should understand the ferocity of repression under Yagoda, Yezhov and Beria, the explanations for the extraordinary extent of this between 1936 and 1938 and its impact on both politics and society. They should understand the 'cult of personality' and its development in the 1930s and during Stalin's last years. They should also understand the concept of 'social realism' as applied to the arts and culture.

The fourth bullet point relates to the USSR's survival and triumph in the Second World War. Students should understand something of the cost and damage inflicted and also the reasons for ultimate Soviet victory, and the significance of this for the USSR's status as a superpower. Students should appreciate the staggering success of maintaining and increasing war production but also the importance of lend-lease. Detailed questions will not be set on particular campaigns or years of the conflict, or on relations with other powers after 1945.